

gurukul also had a shooting range. "I thought at least this would be easier," he thought then.

On his very first shot, Himanshu recalls barely hitting the target. But while shooting was simply the easier of his options, it soon became obvious that he had natural talent. "At first he was using his academy's rifle, but within six months his coach came to me and said he needed to buy an individual air gun. At that time I didn't want to say yes because each one of these guns cost 3 lakh rupees. But Himanshu's coach came to me and said, 'Your son is special'. He said, 'There's no damn way he won't be a successful shooter'," Shamsheer recalls. The family had so much trust in those words that they moved from their village to the town of Kaithal, some 35 kilometres away, where he could train.

Even after the family moved and bought him a gun, Himanshu wasn't completely obsessed with the sport. "I

was like any other child. On some days I would be very dedicated, and other days I just wanted to do *masti* [fun] with my friends," he says.

New purpose

It would take a national lockdown to give him purpose. When India shut down during the COVID-19 pandemic, Himanshu's academy closed as well. He moved back with his family to his village, where he was tasked with working in the family's fields.

He soon realised that he needed to get serious with his life. "*Kheti mere bas ki nahi hai*. I need to focus on a sport *jahan aaram se AC me baith ke shoot goli chala sakte hain* [farm work is out of my ability. I need to focus on a sport where I can sit inside an AC and shoot]," he says.

The reasoning may have been irreverent, but somewhere along the way Himanshu found his calling. As he trained harder, the laziness others

seniors this year, he once again showed just what he's capable of, shooting a mammoth 635.7 in qualification at the Munich World Cup. Those performances helped underline his credentials as he earned a place in the Indian team for the Asian Games.

Thrown into the biggest competition of his career yet, it would have been easy for Himanshu to get overawed by the position he found himself in. But even as he stood next to some of the best shooters in the world, he says he kept his composure. "When you go into the changing room, you see all these great shooters, and you think, what am I doing here? But then you get to the firing line, and you realise that everyone is starting from zero. *Tab dekhte hain kaun sabse tagda*

hai [That's when we can see who is the

best]," he says. And when he prepared to take his first shot, the aggression that Himanshu never knew he had for so long burst forth. "I always think *marunga hi marunga* [I will definitely hit]," he says.

That mentality never changed even as he pushed Lihao to the limit. "I knew I was in the medal race. But I was fully immersed. I was only thinking about following my process, controlling my thinking, controlling my breathing. I told myself to follow the process and *baki jo lagega woh bhad me jaye* [to hell with where the shot goes]," he says.

Although he gave an almighty effort, Himanshu ultimately fell just short. He'll likely have more opportunities to come, perhaps even to get the better of Lihao some day. For now, though, he's more than satisfied with how he's done. As far as 21st birthdays go, he shouldn't have much reason to complain. "I don't think I could have got a better birthday gift," he says.

had once complained about began to disappear.

"I don't think I would have been a good wrestler because I was just very passive. But when I picked up the rifle, all that aggression came naturally to me. When I shoot, I think about how I'm going to hit a big score every time," he says.

Even as he trained more sincerely, Himanshu never lost his slightly uncomplicated view of shooting. "It's not that hard. Shooting is about controlling your feeling, breathing and not thinking so much. In shooting, there's nothing but just doing this," he says.

His potential started to bear out. He came through the junior ranks, making his way through the nationals before eventually earning his first junior team selection last year. Competing in two Junior World Cups in 2025, he won gold in New Delhi. When he moved into the

